



ASTRONAUT

JOB DESCRIPTION

Astronauts are highly trained individuals who pilot spacecraft or carry out specialized missions in space. These may include launching or repairing satellites, or carrying out scientific experiments in low-gravity conditions.

Astronauts are employed by national space agencies, and only a select few ever end up actually traveling into space, making this one of the world's most exclusive careers.



SALARY

Astronaut ★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Very few openings—there have been just over 500 astronauts in total since space flight began • Highly competitive selection process • Many other opportunities in the growing space industry

CAREER PATHS

To be selected as an astronaut, you usually need to be a citizen of the country running a manned space program. You must be physically fit, and meet the space agency's height, weight, and age criteria. Almost all astronauts also hold degrees or higher qualifications in science or engineering, or are skilled and experienced jet pilots. You will undergo multiple rounds of interviews to determine if you are physically and psychologically suited to the role.

JET PILOT You could begin your career by joining your country's military and specializing as a test pilot. You may then be able to apply to join a space program. Most space agencies will require you to hold a degree as a minimum qualification.

SCIENTIST OR ENGINEER You can apply to train as an astronaut if you have a degree—and preferably a postgraduate qualification—in science or engineering, plus flight-related work experience.

INSTRUCTOR Provides training in the skills required to fly and maintain a spacecraft. They use flight simulators to teach new astronauts how to deal with routine operations and potential emergencies.



ASTRONAUT Basic astronaut training takes about two years. If selected for flight, you have a choice of roles, from fixing equipment in Earth's orbit to conducting research on a space station.